

TOPIC 3: FAMILY AS A PRIMARY SOCIAL GROUP

1. Meaning of Family

A family is a group of people related by blood, marriage or adoption who live together or share a common household and have responsibilities towards one another. It is the smallest and most basic unit of society and is called a **primary social group** because it is the first group a person belongs to from birth.

2. Types of Family

a) Nuclear Family

Consists of a father, mother and their children. It is the common type in modern urban settings.

b) Extended Family

Includes the nuclear family plus grandparents, uncles, aunts, cousins and other relatives. This is traditional in many Nigerian communities.

c) Single-Parent Family

One parent (father or mother) living with and raising the children, often due to death, divorce or separation.

d) Compound / Polygamous Family

A family in which a man has more than one wife and children from those wives (common in some cultures).

3. Roles and Responsibilities of Family Members

Roles of the Father / Husband:

- Provides for the financial and material needs of the family.
- Protects and guides the family.
- Makes important decisions in consultation with the mother.
- Serves as a role model for the children.

Roles of the Mother / Wife:

- Cares for the children and manages the home.
- Supports the husband and contributes to family income where possible.
- Teaches moral values and good behaviour.
- Ensures the health and well-being of family members.

Roles of the Children:

- Obey and respect parents and elders.
- Help with household chores.
- Study hard and behave well at home and in school.
- Care for younger siblings and ageing parents later in life.

4. Importance of the Family in Social Development

- It is the first agent of socialization – children learn language, values and behaviour from the family.
- It provides love, care, security and emotional support.

- It transmits culture, religion and traditions from one generation to another.
- It prepares children to become responsible citizens of the larger society.
- A stable family contributes to a peaceful and orderly community.
- It is the foundation of social and economic development.

5. Respect and Cooperation within the Family

For a family to be happy and strong, members must show respect and cooperation:

- Speak politely to one another.
- Listen to each other's views.
- Share responsibilities fairly.
- Resolve disagreements peacefully through dialogue.
- Support one another in times of difficulty.
- Celebrate successes together.

6. Summary

The family is the primary social group and the foundation of society. Different types of families exist, but all require members to perform their roles responsibly. Respect, cooperation and love within the family promote healthy social development and prepare individuals for life in the wider community.

End of Topic 3 – Family as a Primary Social Group